



Parent & Baby Yoga

Handbook





Parent & Baby Yoga

Hi all, thank you for booking my Parent and Baby Yoga course!

When you become a parent, for the first, or the fifth time, your life changes dramatically. As well as being a wonderful time, it can be overwhelming and full of uncertainty.

What better way to help you at this special time than with yoga?

Practicing yoga together gives you and your baby(ies) a special bonding time, playing, moving, breathing and relaxing together in a safe, supportive environment. Specialised post-natal yoga enables you to reconnect with your body, whilst gentle baby yoga can help with colic, digestion, sleep and aid development.

I adore teaching this class and supporting you and your babes as you adjust to parenthood, with some gentle yoga, lush bonding time and relaxation (with a cuppa and cake too)!

I have created this little guide to help you continue your practice at home, please share and tag me in anything you do!

Leanne xx

The benefits of Parent & Baby yoga

- Helps ease common aches and pains
- Helps rebuild a weakened pelvic floor
- Improves core strength
- Reduces stress levels
- Helps you adjust to life as a new parent
- May help minimise postnatal depression
- Strengthens and tones muscles
- Helps bring the tummy muscles back together
- Gives new parents time to relax and take care of themselves
- Helps you accept and love your new post-baby bodies
- Great for bonding with your little ones
- Baby yoga helps with physical development
- Can ease colic and constipation
- Aids good sleep



Baby Holds



You will likely instinctively know how to hold your baby most safely and comfortably.

The three holds below are those you will most likely use during class.

Close to you-

Sat down: Have baby resting against your body, holding them with one arm going across their body and that hand holding them under the opposite arm.

Standing: Have baby's back against your tummy. Hold them with one arm going across their body, the hand supporting them under the opposite arm. The other hand comes up between their legs to take the weight of their lower body.

Flying - only for those with good head control.

Your left arm comes across their body and holds under their right armpit. Your right hand is under their bottom. Slowly lower the left arm so that it is level with the floor - their head will be over your left arm. The right hand will move up to support the baby's belly, which the arm is supporting their bottom.

Under their arms

Have both hands under baby's armpits.

Can work for sitting and standing - again with good head control.

Pranayama (Breathing)

Breath work is integral to yoga and all round wellbeing, practice these breathing Pranayama techniques to help you calm and centre during practice and generally.

- **Long deep breathing**

The benefits of long deep breathing include relaxation, stress release, stimulation of endorphins that fight depression, expansion of lung capacity and an increase in patience. Start by closing the eyes, relaxing the breath and smoothly breathe through the nose. Notice the movement of the abdomen and allow the abdomen to expand. As the slow, deep inhalation is continued, the rib cage and upper chest will also expand. The breath moves into the body like a glass fills with water filling from the lower lungs upwards. Exhale the breath out as a glass would empty, pouring it out from the upper chest, then ribcage, and finally drawing the navel in towards the spine.

- **Ujjayi breath**

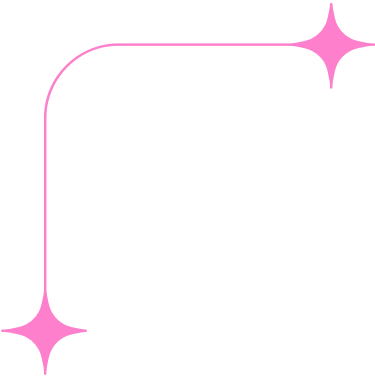
Holding one hand just in front of the mouth, inhale a deep breath through the nose while holding the hand in front of the mouth and then open the mouth and exhale the breath through the mouth, creating a 'haaaaaah' sound. Imagine that the hand is a mirror and that the breath is fogging up the mirror. Now inhale again and on the exhale keep the mouth closed, breathing through the nose. Try to make the same sound as when the mouth was open.

The sounds made during this breathing technique are similar to the sounds of the ocean, which is why this breathing technique is also known as 'oceans breathe'.

- **Golden thread breath**

It's called Golden Thread Breath because it's like blowing a golden thread from your lips gently into the distance or like a fine golden breath spinning out between the lips.

Start by ensuring that your face and jaw are completely relaxed, teeth and lips very slightly apart. Take a deep breath in through the nose, imagining breathing in energy and oxygen into your body and your baby, then a really slow, gentle, controlled breath out through your mouth.



Songs

Open and Close

"Open and close and, open and close and, give yourselves a cuddle,
Open and close and, open and close and don't get in a muddle."

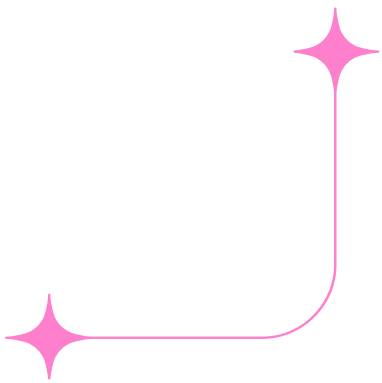
Wind the Bobbin Up

"Wind the bobbin up, wind the bobbin up, pull, pull, clap clap, clap.
Wind it back again, wind it back again, pull, pull, clap, clap, clap.
Point to the ceiling, point to the floor, point to the window and point to
the door,
Clap your hands together, one, two, three, put your hands upon your
knee."

Horsey Horsey

"Horsey Horsey don't you stop,
Just left your feet go clippity clop
You're tail go swish and your wheels go round,
Giddy up, were homeward bound."

Other nursery rhymes:

- Twinkle, twinkle little star
 - You are my sunshine
 - Grand old Duke of York
 - Hickory dickory dock
 - If you're happy and you know it
 - Round and round the garden
 - Incy wincy spider
 - Humpty Dumpty
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Relaxation

Make sure you are as comfortable as possible and if you are able to do so close your eyes and also focus on your breath. Otherwise look at your little babe.

If possible roll onto your back, letting your legs relax onto the floor. You can cuddle your baby in towards you, or have them on a blanket next to you and you can be lying on your side.

Feel fully supported by the ground (or walls/cushions) and take several deep breaths, extending the exhale on each one.

Remain here as long as you wish.

Things which can help with a successful Relaxation:

Blowing bubbles which the babies will watch

Having a little light which projects onto the ceiling of the venue and moves.

Yoga Poses

Asana - Floor

Neck stretch

Drop the right ear over towards the right shoulder. Take 3-5 breaths here. Repeat on the left side.

Progression 1: Reaching the opposite hand away.

Progression 2: Placing the opposite hand on the ear facing the ceiling.

Circling

Place the hands on the knees.

Keeping the spine long, bring the body towards the right leg, forward, to the left and back to centre. This can be helpful for sciatica too.

Forward fold

Scoop your baby up whilst you straighten out your legs in front of you. Place your baby on your thighs face up, and with your hands underneath their upper back, palms face up to support them. Flex your feet so your toes point upwards. Now gently lean forward until you feel the whole of your spine and the back of your legs stretching out. Drop your shoulders and stay here for several breaths

Windscreen wiper legs

Sitting up nice and tall with the feet planted on the floor, hip width or wider apart. Let the knees drop over to the right hand side, then the left, and repeat.

Shoulder rolls

In a comfortable seated position bring the mothers awareness to their posture. As you inhale, roll the shoulders up towards the ears, and as you exhale roll them back and down.

Twist

Inhale the arms up and as you exhale bring the right hand down to the left leg, left hand behind the right hip. Press down into the hands to lift the spine. Repeat on the opposite side.

Progression: As you exhale engage the pelvic floor muscles and bring the belly button towards the spine.

Pelvic floor work - linked to breath
Take a few deep inhales and exhales, really focusing on slowing the exhale down. After three breaths, add in the pelvic floor lift on the exhale. Squeezing up and in. Repeat.

Side stretch

Inhale the right arm up, as you exhale place the left hand on the floor and come reach the right arm up and over. Relax the shoulder down. Send the breath into the side ribs.

Progression: Twist with side stretch. Inhale the arms up, as you exhale take the right hand down to the left leg, turning your body to the left. Keeping the left arm raised, lift from the waist lean over towards the right. Make sure you don't collapse or fold forward but stay nice and open.

Yoga Poses

Table top

Cat - Cow

Begin in box position, with your baby underneath you so you can make eye contact easily. As you exhale round the spine so the chin moves towards the chest and gently draw the abdominal muscles into the spine. Now slowly move the spine in the opposite direction, being careful not to compress the lower back. Move the chin away from the chest and feel the spine lengthen. Draw the shoulders away from the ears. Repeat 3-5 times.

Swooping Cat

Begin in box position, bend the elbows backwards, keeping them tucked into the side of the body, as the hips move backwards towards your heels. When you reach the same level as your baby, kissing them all the way from their toes to their head. When you reach their head press down through the hands to come back up to box position, repeat.

Progression: You can take this into more of a moving cat/cow with kisses.

Child's pose

From box position bring your feet closer to one another so that the big toes touch, move the knees a little wider. Allow the hips to rest on the heels and relax the hands at either side of your baby.

Progression: Place your mouth lightly on their tummy and gently chant Om - they will love it!

Extended child's pose

From box position extend your arms forward so that your spine extends forwards and your head and chest lower towards your baby. Keep the hips directly over the knees and press your hands down firmly into the floor. Give your baby a kiss (or 10) on their tummy.

Swooping arm

From child's pose inhale the right arm forward, circling it up towards the ceiling. As you exhale run your fingers lightly down your baby. Repeat three times. Then on the left hand side.

Chest opener

Return to box position, as you inhale sweep the right arm out to the side and upwards, with the palm of your hand facing outwards. Lower the arm as you exhale and repeat on the other side.

Thread the needle (with chest opener)

From box position walk the hands forward a little. Now inhale the right arm up towards the ceiling and as you exhale, thread it underneath the left arm with the right palm facing upwards. Bend the left arm and bring the right ear towards the ground, next to your baby. Feel the right side of the back stretch. Repeat on the left side. Repeat once more on either side. Now return to child's pose to rest.

Superwoman

From box position bring the belly button towards the spine, keeping the hips level extend the right leg away from you, tucking the toes under. Send the energy out through the heel, and as you inhale raise the leg so that it is parallel with the toes pointing towards the floor. Repeat on the left hand side. Repeat twice more on each side.

Downward facing dog

From box position, tuck the toes under and walk the hands forward a little. Now move the hips up and back and straighten the legs. Let the head and neck relax down and your heels drop towards the floor. You may find your baby will play/grab your hair at this point.

Yoga Poses



Asana - Standing

Chair

Standing with your feet a little wider than hip width apart, press firmly into the feet as you inhale, bend the knees and sweep your arms down, brushing the floor. With your arms extended in front, bring your hands to shoulder height. Slightly tuck the tailbone under. Stay here for a few breaths before releasing.

Eagle

Bring the feet together, bend into the right leg as you lift the left leg up and over to rest on the right thigh. You can have the left toes resting on the floor, floating, or you can go for the full wrap. Hold here for 3-5 breaths. Repeat on the opposite side.

Progression: Add in Eagle arms as well. On an inhale take the arms out wide. As you exhale cross left under right. Bringing the hands together, back to back or palm to palm. Inhale to lift the elbows and hands away from the face. Exhale to sit a little deeper. Repeat on the opposite side.

Standing side bend

Standing in mountain pose with your feet pressing firmly into the ground. On an inhale circle the arms up above the head. As you exhale take a hold of your left wrist with your right hand, and move your left side up and over to the right. Feeling the stretch down your left hand side. Send the breath into the side ribs. Three breaths, then repeat on the opposite side

Low Lunge

From box position, bring the right leg forward to the top of the mat. Pick up your baby and rest them on your right thigh, with their back against your body. Tuck the left toes under and come up on an exhale. Step the feet together.

Hint: If you come up to standing using this, then come back down to the floor in the same way, but with the left leg forward.

Progression: Pelvic floor exercises in low lunge. Before you lift up, do 10-15 pelvic floor contractions, fast or slow, with the breath.

Squats

Hold your baby in towards you with your feet a little wider than hip width apart. Press your feet firmly into the floor and draw the abdominal muscles towards the spine, Bend the knees and tilt the pelvis forward. Slowly straighten the legs, Repeat 6-8 times.

Note: Breath in as you squat and out to come back up.

Progression: As mothers get stronger they may want to add in a lift of their babies, up and down with the squatting movement - this is hard and gets harder the bigger the baby gets.

Yoga Poses



Asana - Standing

Star pose

Holding baby close to you slowly bring the weight into your left leg. Raise the right leg off the floor out to the side. Hold for a few breaths and then repeat on the opposite side.

Warrior 2

Take a wide step towards the front end of the mat. Turn the right foot out to 90 degrees (facing forward) and the back foot is parallel to the back of the mat (turned in a little so as not to over stretch the hip). Whilst holding your baby bend the right leg to a right angle and press the left foot down firmly into the floor. Relax the shoulders and keep the spine straight.

Baby hold: Flying or Close to mum

Progression: Moving Warrior 2. Exactly as above, but inhaling to come into Warrior two and exhaling to come back up.

Tree

Keep holding your baby in towards you and slowly transfer your weight to your left leg. Press the left foot into the floor. Lift the right foot and place the sole of the foot firmly on the inner leg, avoiding the knee joint. Relax the shoulders, elongate the spine and breathe deeply. Repeat on the other side when ready.

Note: You can always start with the toes on the floor.



Yoga Poses



Asana - Supine

Come down onto your back, supporting yourself with one arm as you do so. Once you are safely on your back place your baby either lying, or seated on your tummy, whatever works best for you so you are both comfortable.

Shoulder bridge

Now bend your knees and align the feet so the ankles are directly under your knees with your feet about hip width apart. Holding your baby firmly as you exhale lift the hips and spine up to create a bridge position. Lift high enough so that you feel the glutes working and try and engage the pelvic floor as you lift. Now slowly lower the hips and spine back down to the floor. Keep the feet flat on the floor to avoid any undue tension in the lower back. You may also like to have a cushion under your head for extra comfort. Repeat 8-10 times.

Lying chest opener

Place your baby next to you on your mat/their blanket and slowly roll onto your left hand side to face them. Bend your legs and reach your arms out directly in front of you at shoulder height. Slowly lift the right arm up towards the ceiling, following the arm with your gaze. Allow the arm to stretch out behind you, letting the upper body rotate a little at the same time. Feel the stretch across the chest. Slowly bring the hands back together, repeat 8 times on each side.

Flying from the floor (Horsey Horsey)

From semi supine press your lower back into the ground. Lift the legs into a right angle position with the knees over the hips and contract the abdominal muscles. Place your baby's face down onto your lower legs (baby's head near mothers knees), which at this point are level to the ground. Hold your baby on your legs (under the arms tends to work best) and slowly lower your feet part way to the ground, keeping the thighs perpendicular to the ground. Repeat several times as you sing the song "Horsey Horsey".

Supine twist

With the hips resting on the ground, let the legs drop over to the right side. Sit your baby on your left hip. Pause here before moving the legs back to centre (and your baby) and then letting them drop over onto the left side, with your baby now sitting on your right hip.

Yoga Poses



Baby Yoga

Sweep down baby - Massage/gentle squeezes

Making eye contact with your baby, lean or fold forward, keeping the spine as straight as possible. Starting at the head, stroke/massage/squeeze gently all the way down their body five times. Use your scarf.

Tummy rub

Place the heel of your hand on your baby's tummy and make circles on her tummy area. Always go clockwise as this is the direction of the digestive system. This gentle tummy rub is effective at relieving wind and constipation. Spend 20-30 seconds doing this.

Arm stretch - Wind the Bobbin

With your baby sat in your lap, resting against you, take their arms gently in your hands. As you sing the song gently circle their arms together in one direction, and then the other. Take them up to the ceiling, down to the floor, to the right then left, following the words of the song.

Alternate leg stretch - Hickory Dickory Dock

Lift up one of your baby's legs. We are going to move first towards their other leg, then across the hip, then thirdly in the direction of the opposite shoulder whilst singing this song

Foot Rub

Gently hold your baby's feet and press your thumbs lightly into the soles of their feet. Now rub up and down the soles of her feet with your thumbs. Their toes will curl around your thumbs. Spend 20-30 seconds doing this.

Leg circles with feet together

Bring your babies feet together, sole to sole, holding both feet in one hand. Then moving to the right circle the feet around 6 times.

Arm and chest stretch – Open and Close song

Gently bring your babies hands together at her chest and then stretch them out to either side. On the words “muddle” and “cuddle” you can do a gentle rock from side to side with both hands in at the chest.

Heads, Shoulders, Knees and Toes

With your baby in your lap resting against your body move their hands with the words of the songs.

Example session plan:

Breath work
Seated Shoulder rolls.
Shoulder Circles
Pelvic floor with breath
Arms out and up three times
Side stretch

Table top
Cat/cow
Swooping cat kisses
Child's pose
Superwoman - legs only
Extended child's pose
Standing
Down dog
Rag doll

Standing
Mountain pose
Standing side bend
Chair pose
Hip circles

Baby Flow
Wide leg sweep down baby
Foot rub
Open and close
Leg circles
Marching legs - Grand old Duke
of York

Mum with baby flow
Low lunge - with Pelvic floor work
High Lunge
Mountain pose
Hip circles
Squats
High lunge
Low lunge - with pelvic floor work

Cool down
Windscreen wiper legs
Shoulder bridge
Supine twist

Savasana (Relaxation)

